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2027 CYCLE

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CUET UG

Political Science

South Asia in the Post Cold War Era

Official Syllabus · Contemporary World Politics · Class 12 · CUET UG 2027 Cycle Notes

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Syllabus Alignment

Sub-topic	Official syllabus pointer (NTA CUET(UG) Political Science syllabus 2026, the current 2027 baseline — Contemporary World Politics)	Skills the questions test
Democratisation in Pakistan	Democratisation and its reversals in Pakistan; military rule versus civilian governance.	Identifying military dictators (Ayub, Yahya, Zia, Musharraf), democratic phases (Bhutto, Benazir, Nawaz), and structural obstacles to democracy.
Democracy in Nepal	Democratisation and its reversals in Nepal; transition from monarchy to republic.	Tracing the 1990 movement, the Maoist insurgency (1996–2006), the April 2006 mass uprising, and the formal abolition of the monarchy in 2008.
Sri Lanka's Ethnic Conflict	Ethnic conflict in Sri Lanka; Sinhala majoritarianism, LTTE insurgency, and peace efforts.	Analyzing the 1956 Sinhala Only Act, LTTE formation (1976), the Indian Peace Keeping Force (IPKF 1987–90), and the military endgame of May 2009.
Bangladesh & Maldives	Democratic trajectories in Bangladesh and the Maldives.	Recalling the 1971 Liberation War, Mujib's Awami League, 1990 pro-democracy movement, and Maldives' transition from Sultanate to multi-party democracy (2005).
Regional Peace & SAARC	Conflicts and efforts for peace in South Asia; SAARC and SAFTA.	Detailing the 1985 Dhaka SAARC charter, admission of Afghanistan (2007), SAFTA agreement (2004/2006), and bi-

Sub-topic	Official syllabus pointer (NTA CUET(UG) Political Science syllabus 2026, the current 2027 baseline — Contemporary World Politics)	Skills the questions test
		lateral security bottlenecks.
India & Its Neighbours	India's relations with its neighbours; river water disputes, security treaties, and economic cooperation.	Evaluating the 1960 Indus Waters Treaty, the 1996 Ganga Water Treaty, 2015 Land Boundary Agreement, and Operation Cactus (1988).

CUET UG Exam Strategy — Chapter 3 Focus (World Politics)

- **Pattern:** 50 Multiple Choice Questions (attempt any 40) in 60 minutes.
- **Marking:** +5 marks for correct choice, −1 mark negative deduction for incorrect choice.
- **High-Yield Angles:** Dates of SAARC and SAFTA, the 8th member of SAARC (Afghanistan, 2007), IPKF deployment (1987) and withdrawal (1990), Nepal monarchy abolition year (2008), and landmark river treaties.

1. Geopolitics of South Asia: Unity Amidst Diversity

The expression **"South Asia"** points to a geographically distinct and culturally interconnected region bounded by the Himalayas in the north, the Indian Ocean in the south, the Arabian Sea in the west, and the Bay of Bengal in the east.

Geographical and Political Contours

- **Member States:** Comprises seven foundational sovereign nations: **India, Pakistan, Bangladesh, Sri Lanka, Nepal, Bhutan, and the Maldives**. (Afghanistan was integrated into the regional architecture in 2007 through SAARC).
- **Plurality of Political Systems:**
  - **Stable Constitutional Democracies:** India and Sri Lanka have successfully operated uninterrupted multi-party democracies since independence.
  - **Alternating Military & Civilian Rule:** Pakistan and Bangladesh have oscillated between military dictatorships and civilian democracies.
  - **Transition from Monarchy to Republic:** Nepal transformed from an absolute Hindu monarchy into a constitutional monarchy (1990), and ultimately into a secular federal republic (2008).
  - **Evolution from Sultanate:** The Maldives functioned as a Sultanate until 1968, shifting to a presidential republic and legalizing multi-party democracy in 2005.
  - **Democratic Monarchy:** Bhutan transitioned peacefully into a constitutional monarchy with a multi-party parliamentary system in 2008 under its Fourth King.

2. Pakistan: The Fragile Rhythm of Democracy and Military Rule

Pakistan's political history reflects an entrenched structural tension between elected civilian administrations and powerful military regimes.

Chronology of Military Regimes

- **General Ayub Khan (1958–1969):** Seized power by declaring martial law, promulgated Pakistan's 1962 Constitution, but was forced to resign following popular mass protests against rising inequality and the 1965 war with India.
- **General Yahya Khan (1969–1971):** Imposed martial law; presided over the 1970 elections where the Bengali-dominated Awami League swept East Pakistan. Resigned in disgrace following Pakistan's crushing defeat in the December 1971 Liberation War.
- **Zulfikar Ali Bhutto (1971–1977):** Re-established civilian democratic governance under the Pakistan People's Party (PPP), promulgating the 1973 Constitution. Deposed in a military coup in July 1977.
- **General Zia-ul-Haq (1977–1988):** Imposed a repressive 11-year military dictatorship; executed Zulfikar Ali Bhutto in 1979; institutionalized hardline state Islamization and coordinated Afghan Mujahideen resistance against the Soviets with US funding.
- **General Pervez Musharraf (1999–2008):** Overthrew Prime Minister Nawaz Sharif in a bloodless coup on 12 October 1999 following the Kargil conflict; conducted a controversial presidential referendum in 2002; forced to step down in 2008 amid widespread judicial and political agitations.

Structural Obstacles to Sustainable Democracy

- **The "Military-Mullah-Feudal" Nexus:** The military establishment (**the "Deep State"**), orthodox religious clergy, and powerful feudal landlords exercise veto power over civilian institutions.
- **Strategic External Sponsorship:** During the Cold War and the Post-9/11 War on Terror, the United States, Western powers, and China provided extensive military and financial aid to military dictatorships in Pakistan, prioritizing geostrategic utility over democratic values.
- **India Obsession:** Hostility with India over Jammu & Kashmir has historically been exploited by the armed forces to justify disproportionate defense expenditures and undermine elected civilian governments.

3. Bangladesh: The Liberation Struggle and Democratic Consolidation

Bangladesh emerged as a sovereign nation out of a fierce rebellion against West Pakistani ethnic, linguistic, and economic domination.

The 1971 Liberation Struggle

- **Post-Partition Grievances:** Although Bengalis in East Pakistan constituted the majority of Pakistan's population, they suffered systematic economic exploitation and cultural disenfranchisement (such as the imposition of Urdu as the sole state language).
- **Sheikh Mujibur Rahman's Leadership:** Sheikh Mujib led the **Awami League** to a landslide victory in the 1970 general elections, demanding regional autonomy under his famous **Six-Point Programme**.
- **Operation Searchlight (March 1971):** The Pakistani military launched a genocidal crackdown on unarmed Bengali civilians, students, and intellectuals in Dhaka. Sheikh Mujib was arrested, and millions of refugees fled into neighboring Indian states (West Bengal, Tripura, Assam).
- **Indian Military Assistance & Birth of Bangladesh:** Prime Minister Indira Gandhi supported the Bengali guerrilla force (**Mukti Bahini**). On 3 December 1971, Pakistan attacked Indian airbases, sparking a 13-day war. Over 93,000 Pakistani soldiers surrendered in Dhaka on **16 December 1971**, resulting in the birth of independent Bangladesh.

Authoritarian Lapses and Multi-Party Consolidation

- **Sheikh Mujib's Tragic End:** In 1975, Sheikh Mujib amended the Constitution to establish a one-party presidential system (**BAKSAL**). On 15 August 1975, he was assassinated alongside most of his family in a military coup.
- **Military Rule (1975–1990):** Successive military dictators—General **Ziaur Rahman** (founder of the Bangladesh Nationalist Party, BNP) and General **H.M. Ershad**—ruled the nation.
- **Democratic Restoration (1990):** A massive nationwide mass pro-democracy uprising forced General Ershad to resign in December 1990, restoring multi-party parliamentary democracy, with power alternating between Sheikh Hasina (Awami League) and Begum Khaleda Zia (BNP).

4. Nepal: Transition from Hindu Monarchy to Federal Republic

For centuries, Nepal remained a landlocked kingdom ruled by the Shah dynasty, functioning as the world's only official Hindu state.

The Democratic Movement of 1990

- A popular mass pro-democracy movement (**Jana Andolan I**) forced King Birendra to yield absolute power and promulgate a new Constitution in 1990, establishing a constitutional monarchy with a multi-party parliamentary system.

The Triangular Conflict (1996–2006)

- Throughout the late 1990s and early 2000s, Nepal was engulfed in a three-way struggle among:
  1. **The Royal Monarchy & Army:** Seeking to retain absolute power and privilege.
  2. **Parliamentary Democratic Parties:** Advocating constitutional rule and human rights.

3. **Maoist Insurgents:** The Communist Party of Nepal (Maoist) led by Prachanda launched a "People's War" in 1996, taking control of large rural swathes through guerrilla warfare.

King Gyanendra's Takeover and the April 2006 Uprising

- Following the mysterious palace massacre in June 2001, King Gyanendra ascended the throne. In October 2002 and February 2005, he dismissed the elected Prime Minister, dissolved Parliament, and assumed absolute executive power.
- **Historic 12-Point Agreement (November 2005):** The **Seven Party Alliance (SPA)** of mainstream political parties joined hands with the underground Maoists in New Delhi to forge a united democratic front against the monarchy.
- **Jana Andolan II (April 2006):** Millions of Nepalese citizens staged a 19-day general strike in Kathmandu. King Gyanendra was forced to capitulate, reinstating the dissolved House of Representatives.
- **Abolition of Monarchy (2008):** The newly elected Constituent Assembly officially **abolished the 240-year-old monarchy on 28 May 2008**, declaring Nepal a secular, federal democratic republic. In **2015**, Nepal formally adopted its modern democratic republican constitution.

5. Sri Lanka: Sinhala Majoritarianism and Ethnic Strife

Sri Lanka (formerly Ceylon) achieved independence from British rule in 1948. While it preserved an unbroken democratic framework, its peace was shattered by violent ethnic civil war.

Roots of the Ethnic Divide

- **Demographic Composition:** The Buddhist **Sinhalese** constitute roughly 74% of the population, while **Tamils** (native Sri Lankan Tamils in the north and east, and Indian Tamils on central tea plantations) form around 18%.
- **Sinhala Majoritarianism:** Post-independence Sinhala politicians enacted majoritarian legislation:
  - **The Sinhala Only Act (1956):** Replaced English with Sinhala as the sole official language of administration and courts, disenfranchising Tamil speakers.
  - **University Standardization Policies:** Imposed discriminatory quotas restricting Tamil student admissions into engineering and medical colleges.
  - **State-Sponsored Colonization:** Resettled Sinhalese peasants into traditionally Tamil-majority northern and eastern provinces.

The Rise of Armed Tamil Militancy (LTTE)

- **Formation of LTTE (1976):** Frustrated by peaceful political failure, **Velupillai Prabhakaran** formed the **Liberation Tigers of Tamil Eelam (LTTE)** in 1976, launching an armed guerrilla war demanding an independent homeland—**Tamil Eelam**—in northern and eastern Sri Lanka.
- **1983 Anti-Tamil Pogrom ("Black July"):** Brutal state-sanctioned anti-Tamil riots in Colombo killed thousands, driving hundreds of thousands of Tamil refugees to Tamil Nadu and radicalizing the insurgency.

Indian Intervention and the IPKF (1987–1990)

- **Indo-Sri Lanka Peace Accord (29 July 1987):** Signed in Colombo by Prime Minister Rajiv Gandhi and President J.R. Jayewardene. Sri Lanka agreed to devolve power to provincial councils (the **13th Constitutional Amendment**), while India agreed to deploy the **Indian Peace Keeping Force (IPKF)** to disarm the militants.
- **Disastrous Entanglement:** The LTTE refused to lay down arms, dragging the IPKF into fierce combat in the Jaffna peninsula. Local Sinhalese resented the presence of Indian troops on sovereign soil.
- **Withdrawal (March 1990):** In 1990, Prime Minister V.P. Singh's National Front government pulled the IPKF out of Sri Lanka after the loss of over 1,100 Indian soldiers.
- **Assassination of Rajiv Gandhi (1991):** Seeking revenge against Indian intervention, an LTTE suicide bomber assassinated Rajiv Gandhi at Sriperumbudur on 21 May 1991.

Defeat of the LTTE (May 2009)

- Following the failure of Norwegian-mediated peace talks (2002–2006), the Sri Lankan military launched an all-out offensive under President Mahinda Rajapaksa. In May 2009, the LTTE was crushed, Prabhakaran was killed in Mullaitivu, and government forces established complete territorial control.
- **Socio-Economic Resilience:** Despite 26 years of civil war, Sri Lanka was one of the first developing nations to successfully liberalize its economy (1977), maintaining the highest Human Development Index (HDI) and literacy rates in South Asia.

6. The Maldives: From Sultanate to Multi-Party Democracy

- **Constitutional Evolution:** The Maldives was a British protectorate that became independent in 1965. It transformed from a centuries-old Islamic **Sultanate into a presidential republic in 1968**.
- **Operation Cactus (November 1988):** A group of Sri Lankan Tamil mercenaries belonging to PLOTE attempted a violent coup to overthrow President Maumoon Abdul Gayoom. Upon a distress appeal from Male, Prime Minister Rajiv Gandhi dispatched Indian paratroopers and naval warships (**Operation Cactus**), neutralizing the coup plotters within hours.
- **Multi-Party Transition (2005 Onwards):** Following mass democratic protests against authoritarian rule, the Maldivian parliament voted unanimously to legalize political parties in **June 2005**. In 2008, **Mohamed Nasheed** of the Maldivian Democratic Party (MDP) was elected President in the country's first multi-party democratic election.

7. Regional Cooperation and Peace Efforts: SAARC & SAFTA

Recognizing shared geographical proximity, common developmental challenges, and cross-border connectivity, South Asian nations created institutional structures for regional cooperation.

SAARC (South Asian Association for Regional Cooperation)

- **Founding (December 1985):** Established at the first regional summit in **Dhaka (Bangladesh)** with seven original member states.
- **Secretariat:** Located in **Kathmandu, Nepal**.
- **Expansion (2007): Afghanistan** was officially inducted as the eighth member state at the 14th SAARC Summit in New Delhi in April 2007.
- **Core Principle:** All collective decisions require unanimity; **bilateral and contentious political disputes are strictly barred** from formal SAARC deliberations.

SAFTA (South Asian Free Trade Area)

- **Signing (January 2004):** Signed by member states at the 12th SAARC Summit in Islamabad.
- **Implementation:** Entered into force on **1 January 2006**, seeking to reduce customs duties on merchandise trade by 20% across the region.
- **Challenges:** Intra-regional trade within SAARC remains stubbornly below 5% of its total global trade, hampered by political hostility between India and Pakistan and non-tariff barriers.

8. India's Bilateral Neighborhood Relations

Country	Key Accords & Areas of Co-operation	Major Bilateral Friction Points
Pakistan	Indus Waters Treaty (1960, brokered by World Bank); Simla Agreement (1972); Lahore Declaration (1999).	Jammu & Kashmir dispute; cross-border terrorism (2001 Parliament, 2008 Mumbai, 2016 Uri); Siachen Glacier and Sir Creek boundary disputes.
Bangladesh	30-year Ganga Water Treaty (1996); historic Land Boundary Agreement (2015 swap of 162 enclaves); duty-free trade access.	Teesta river water sharing deadlock; illegal migration concerns; cross-border cattle smuggling.
Nepal	1950 Indo-Nepal Treaty of Peace and Friendship (visa-free travel and employment for citizens); hydro-power projects.	Territorial disputes over Kalapani-Limpiyadhura-Lipulekh; Chinese infrastructure influence (BRI).
Bhutan	Special friendship treaty (1949/2007); major hydroelectric power generation (Chukha, Kurichhu, Tala) exporting electricity to India.	Minimal friction; shared security concerns regarding Chinese incursions at the Doklam tri-junction (2017).

Country	Key Accords & Areas of Co-operation	Major Bilateral Friction Points
Maldives	Operation Cactus (1988); humanitarian freshwater airlift (Operation Neer 2014); Greater Male Connectivity Project.	Shifting domestic politics; domestic "India Out" campaigns; maritime balance of power with China.

The Whole Chapter in One Picture



Figure 1: Contemporary South Asia Mindmap: Pakistan's military-democratic cycles, Bangladesh liberation, Nepal's democratic revolution, Sri Lanka's ethnic conflict, and SAARC.

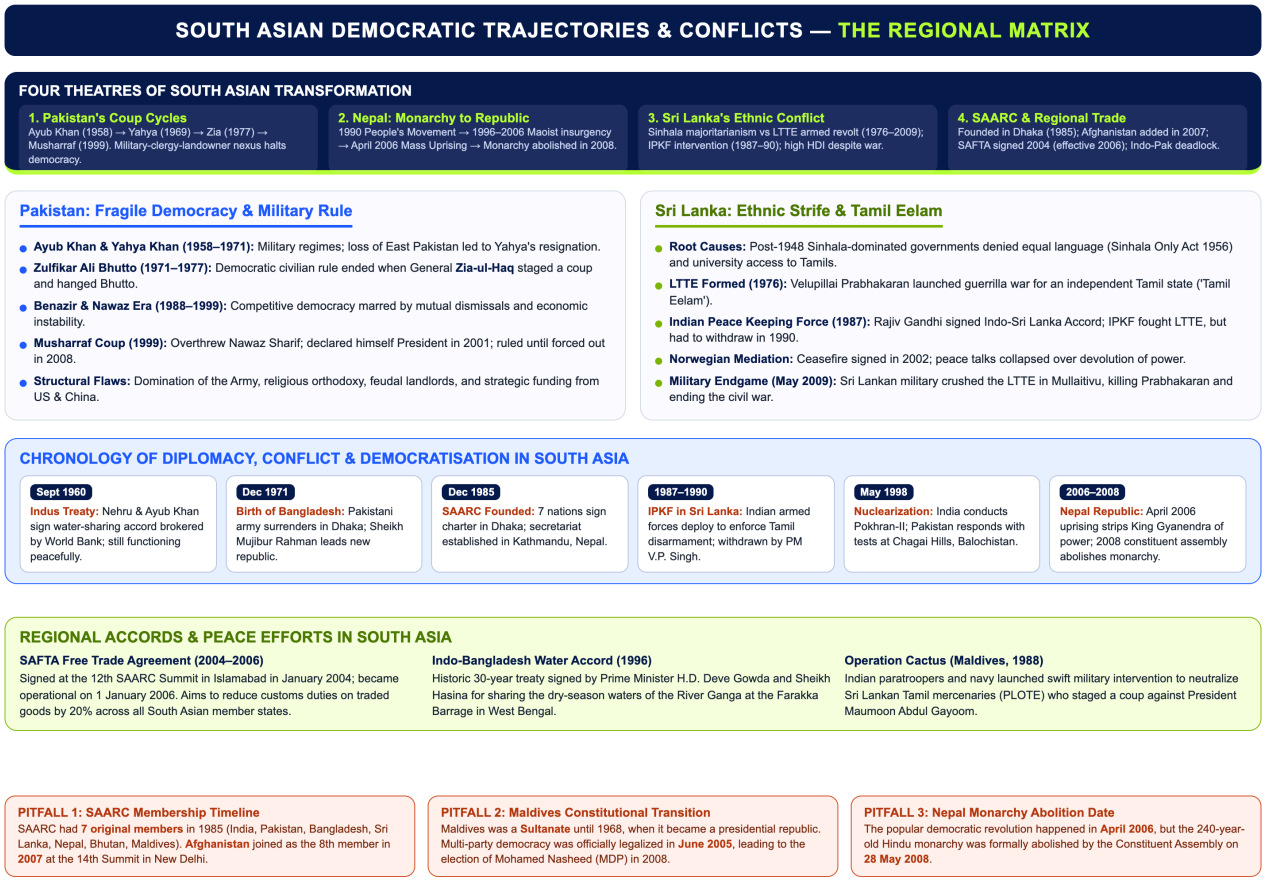


Figure 2: Regional Trajectories Matrix: Chronology of diplomacy and conflict, SAARC/SAFTA treaties, IPKF timeline, and core exam pitfalls.

Practice Questions (Exam Pattern)

Ten questions designed in authentic CUET UG single-correct style. The official marking scheme awards +5 for each correct answer and deducts −1 for every incorrect answer.

Q1. In which year did Pakistan conduct underground nuclear tests in the Chagai Hills, formally declaring itself a nuclear weapons state?

(A) 1974 (B) 1988
(C) 1998 (D) 2001

Q2. Who led the Awami League in East Pakistan and championed the historic Six-Point Movement demanding regional autonomy in 1970?

(A) Ziaur Rahman (B) Sheikh Mujibur Rahman
(C) H.M. Ershad (D) Maulana Bhashani

Q3. On which date did the 240-year-old Hindu monarchy formally come to an end in Nepal, declaring it a secular federal republic?

(A) 1990 (B) April 2006
(C) May 2008 (D) September 2015

Q4. The controversial legislation passed in Sri Lanka in 1956 that recognized Sinhala as the sole official language of administration is known as the:

(A) Ceylon Independence Act
(B) Sinhala Only Act
(C) 13th Amendment Act
(D) Tamil Disfranchisement Act

Q5. The Indian Peace Keeping Force (IPKF) was sent to Sri Lanka in 1987 under the tenure of Rajiv Gandhi, and was pulled back in 1990 by which Prime Minister?

(A) Indira Gandhi
(B) V.P. Singh
(C) Chandra Shekhar
(D) P.V. Narasimha Rao

Q6. Operation Cactus (November 1988) was a swift military intervention conducted by Indian armed forces to save the government of which South Asian nation?

(A) Sri Lanka
(B) Bhutan
(C) Maldives
(D) Nepal

Q7. In which city was the South Asian Association for Regional Cooperation (SAARC) formally established in December 1985?

(A) New Delhi
(B) Kathmandu
(C) Islamabad
(D) Dhaka

Q8. Which country was officially inducted as the eighth member state of SAARC at the 14th Summit held in New Delhi in April 2007?

(A) Myanmar
(B) Afghanistan
(C) Maldives
(D) Mauritius

Q9. The South Asian Free Trade Area (SAFTA) agreement was signed in 2004 and came into formal legal operation on which date?

(A) 1 January 2004
(B) 1 January 2006
(C) 15 August 2007
(D) 1 January 2010

Q10. The historic 30-year treaty for sharing the dry-season waters of the River Ganga at the Farakka Barrage was signed between India and Bangladesh in which year?

(A) 1971
(B) 1985
(C) 1996
(D) 2015

Detailed Solutions

Sol. Q1. In late May 1998, Pakistan conducted five nuclear tests in the Chagai Hills of Balochistan in direct response to India's Pokhran-II tests, establishing mutual nuclear deterrence.

Answer: (C)

Sol. Q2. Sheikh Mujibur Rahman ('Bangabandhu') founded the Awami League and launched the Six-Point Movement in 1966, sweeping the 1970 elections and leading Bangladesh to independence in 1971.

Answer: (B)

Sol. Q3. On 28 May 2008, the first meeting of Nepal's newly elected Constituent Assembly officially abolished the monarchy, establishing a secular federal democratic republic.

Answer: (C)

Sol. Q4. The Sinhala Only Act of 1956 declared Sinhala as the sole official language of Ceylon, igniting peaceful protests by Tamils and laying the ground for armed civil strife.

Answer: (B)

Sol. Q5. The IPKF was deployed in 1987 by Rajiv Gandhi; following immense domestic criticism and heavy casualties, it was officially pulled out in March 1990 by Prime Minister V.P. Singh.

Answer: (B)

Sol. Q6. Operation Cactus was launched on 3 November 1988 by the Indian military to foil an armed coup against Maldivian President Maumoon Abdul Gayoom carried out by Sri Lankan mercenaries.

Answer: (C)

Sol. Q7. SAARC was founded on 8 December 1985 in Dhaka (Bangladesh). Its permanent Secretariat was later established in Kathmandu (Nepal).

Answer: (D)

Sol. Q8. Afghanistan was formally admitted as the eighth member of SAARC at the 14th New Delhi Summit in April 2007, marking the first expansion of the association since 1985.

Answer: (B)

Sol. Q9. SAFTA was signed at the 12th SAARC Summit in Islamabad in January 2004 and officially came into force on 1 January 2006 to lower regional customs tariffs.

Answer: (B)

Sol. Q10. Prime Minister H.D. Deve Gowda and Bangladeshi Prime Minister Sheikh Hasina signed the historic 30-year Ganga Water Sharing Treaty at Farakka in December 1996.

Answer: (C)

Wrong-Answer Clinic — the one-line corrections

If you answered...	Your slip was...	The corrected rule, in one line
Q3 option B	Confusing the April 2006 uprising with formal abolition	The uprising forced the King to yield in April 2006; the assembly formally abolished the throne on 28 May 2008.
Q5 option D	Swapping the withdrawal Prime Minister	Rajiv Gandhi deployed the IPKF (1987); V.P. Singh ordered its complete withdrawal (1990).
Q7 option B	Confusing SAARC founding city with Secretariat city	SAARC was founded in **Dhaka** (1985); its Secretariat is in **Kathmandu**.
Q8 option A	Selecting Myanmar instead of Afghanistan	Myanmar is a member of ASEAN; Afghanistan is the 8th member of SAARC.
Q9 option A	Confusing signing date with operational date	SAFTA was signed in January 2004, but became operational on 1 January 2006.

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